

CSS121

Introduction to Psychology

Course Summary

Ubora World Study Companion

About This Summary

This summary condenses the core ideas of CSS121 (Introduction to Psychology) into a quick-reference study guide. It covers all 4 modules and 20 study units: foundations of psychology, intelligence and behaviour, person perception, and social behaviour. Use it to revise before practicing with the CBT question bank, not as a replacement for the full course material.

Module 1: Foundations of Psychology

The Concept of Psychology

Psychology emerged as a formal discipline in 1879 in Leipzig, Germany, where Wilhelm Wundt founded the first laboratory devoted to experimental psychology. Psychologists do not always agree on a single definition because the field is relatively new and covers a very diverse range of subjects. Broadly, psychology is the scientific study of behaviour, going beyond the layman's view that it is "just common sense."

Approaches to Psychology

Different schools of thought explain behaviour differently: the biological approach looks to brain functioning and biochemical processes; the psychodynamic approach (linked to Sigmund Freud) sees behaviour as rooted in inherited instincts and unresolved early-life conflicts; the behaviourist approach (linked to B.F. Skinner) focuses on observable behaviour shaped by the environment; and the cognitive approach centres on thinking, perception, memory, and problem-solving.

Some Basic Concepts in Psychology

Learning is understood differently across theorists, but broadly means a relatively permanent change in behaviour resulting from experience and practice. Maturation, by contrast, is an internal, biological process of development that happens with or without learning. Growth and development follow general principles: they are orderly, continuous, and shaped heavily during the earliest years of a person's life.

Specialties in Psychology

Psychology branches into many applied specialties: educational psychology (helping children learn), clinical psychology (treating mental illness and behavioural problems), social psychology (studying institutions and their effect on individuals), occupational health psychology (workplace wellbeing), community psychology (family and rehabilitation programmes), and forensic psychology (crime and the legal system), among others.

How Psychologists Develop and Test their Theories

Psychologists rely on the scientific method to test their ideas, since it allows hypotheses to be tested systematically, guards against results being due to chance, and lets other researchers verify findings independently. Common methods include naturalistic observation, case studies, surveys/questionnaires, correlational studies, and controlled experiments.

Module 2: Intelligence, Behaviour, and Perception

Definitions of Intelligence

Psychologists define intelligence in various ways: as the capacity for abstract thinking, the ability to adapt to one's environment, or the capacity to learn from experience. Intelligence Quotient (IQ) is calculated by dividing an individual's mental age by their chronological age and multiplying by 100, giving an index of how advanced or behind a person is relative to their age group.

Individual Differences in Intelligence

Intelligence scores in a population tend to follow a normal probability curve, with most people clustering around average and progressively fewer people at the very low and very high ends. This unit also covers the debate over whether simple IQ measures adequately capture intelligence, and introduces the concept of deviation IQ as an alternative measure.

Explaining Behaviour: Genetic and Environmental Influences

This is the heart of the long-running "nature versus nurture" debate. Genetics may set the outer limits of certain behaviours, but the environment strongly determines which genetic tendencies actually get expressed. Twin studies (comparing identical and non-identical twins) are a key research tool for separating genetic from environmental influence.

Applying Psychology to Policing

Psychological principles are applied to police work either through psychologists working directly within police organisations or through psychological theories being built into officer training. This unit also weighs the advantages (independence, confidentiality) and disadvantages (limited feedback, being seen as an outsider) of a psychologist acting as an external consultant to law enforcement.

Perception: A Basic Process

Perception is the psychological process by which sensory information is organised and interpreted, and it underlies nearly all learning and behaviour. Because people are constantly confronted with more stimuli than they can attend to, perception mechanisms (such as grouping, similarity, and proximity of stimuli) determine what gets noticed and how it is interpreted, and this can differ between individuals even when facing the exact same stimulus.

Module 3: Person Perception and Social Judgment

Impression Formation

When forming impressions of other people, we rely heavily on physical cues and salient (standout) information. This unit covers the general principles behind how first impressions get built from limited information, and why certain cues carry more weight than others.

Understanding Important Factors in Person Perception and Impression Formation

Building on impression formation, this unit examines the specific factors — such as social categories like gender, ethnicity, and social class — that shape how we perceive and categorise other people, often immediately and automatically.

Personality Trait Inferences about What the Person is Like

This unit covers how perceivers move from observed behaviour to inferring underlying personality traits, and how social categories continue to influence these trait judgments, often without the perceiver being fully aware of the bias.

Understanding and Attributing Causes to Others' Behaviour

People are often motivated to understand *why* someone acted a certain way. This unit covers attribution — the process of assigning causes to others' behaviour — along with the role of affective (emotional) cues in shaping those attributions.

Accuracy of Judgments

For society to function smoothly, people need to be reasonably accurate at judging one another. This unit covers the cues people rely on to judge personality and recognise emotions, noting that certain emotional cues are recognised in strikingly similar ways across different people and cultures.

Module 4: Social Behaviour and Its Management

The Problem of Deception

Deception operates through non-verbal channels of communication, including "leakage" (non-verbal acts that unintentionally reveal concealed information) and deception cues (acts that hint deception is occurring without revealing what is being concealed). Factors influencing successful deception include the deceiver's motivation, experience, self-confidence, and how well the deception was planned in advance.

Socialisation

Socialisation is the process by which an individual grows into a full member of society, necessarily involving contact with other people. Major socialisation agents include the family, the school, the peer group, and the mass media. Sociometry, a related concept, is the study of patterns of interrelationship within a group of people.

Juvenile Delinquency

Delinquency is understood as a form of maladjustment, often generated by dysfunction in the family, peer group, or mass media influence. Warning signs include extreme restlessness, hostility, truancy, and a lack of apparent moral standards. Addressing it requires coordinated attention from schools, teachers, and social service agencies supporting families.

Behaviour Modification

This unit covers the deliberate management of deviant or unwanted behaviour, including the types and frequency of deviant behaviour and the methods (such as operant conditioning-based techniques) available for controlling and reshaping behaviour over time.

Human Aggression

Aggression is defined as behaviour aimed at injuring the person it is directed toward, and it takes several forms: instrumental aggression (aimed at achieving an external goal), displaced aggression (redirected toward a different target), and hostile aggression (aimed purely at causing harm). The Frustration-Aggression theory holds that aggression often results when goal-directed activity is blocked. The unit closes with strategies for managing and reducing aggressive behaviour.

Quick Revision Checklist

- Know when and where psychology emerged as a formal discipline, and who founded the first experimental lab.
- Be able to distinguish the biological, psychodynamic, behaviourist, and cognitive approaches to psychology.
- Understand the difference between learning (experience-based) and maturation (biological).
- Be able to list at least 4-5 specialties within psychology and what each focuses on.
- Know why psychologists rely on the scientific method rather than casual observation.
- Understand how IQ is calculated ($\text{mental age} \div \text{chronological age} \times 100$).
- Be able to explain the nature vs. nurture debate and how twin studies help separate the two.
- Understand what perception is and why two people can perceive the same stimulus differently.
- Know the difference between impression formation and personality trait inference.
- Be able to define attribution and explain its role in judging others' behaviour.
- Know the main agents of socialisation: family, school, peer group, mass media.
- Be able to distinguish instrumental, displaced, and hostile aggression, and explain the Frustration-Aggression theory.